

DVD Switch

Q I read the review of the Mitashi DIVX-555 DivX player, and was planning on buying it. I'd like to know of a dealer in Kolkata. I am also planning to buy a DVD-Writer, and would like to know about the best one that would be available around Kolkata.

Appusarkar

 The Mitashi DIVX-555 player is available through Mitashi Edutainment Pvt Ltd, a Mumbai-based company. You can contact them on 022-25006661 and find out about their branch in Kolkata. As for the DVD writer, I suggest you go for the Lite-On 1653S, which costs around Rs 4K and can burn DVDs at 16X. It also supports dual layer +R at 6X.

Print To CD

Q I want to buy a printer that can print directly on CDs, that is, I want to print the CD face directly on the CDs rather than printing it on paper and then pasting that onto the CD. What model would you suggest I go for? My budget is around Rs 8K.

Anil

 There are quite a few models from Epson and Canon that offer CD face printing via an attachment. As far as Epson is concerned, the printing quality is not as great as Canon's—I'd suggest Canon over Epson. Canon's new line of Pixma printers has the CD face printing feature in their mid- and top-range printers.

Digit evaluated two of these—the Pixma IP3000 and IP4000—both of which have the CD printing feature. The IP3000, though, costs around Rs 8,495 while the IP 4000 will set you back by Rs 10,995. Speed and cosmetic differences apart, the two models are virtually the same, and you can safely settle for the IP3000 model. Remember that for printing on CDs, you need printable CDs that support this feature.

MP3, FM Radio And Warranty

Q I am looking to buy an MP3 player that suits my needs—a Flash-based device with 256 MB capacity and with FM radio. I would like a player that uses normal batteries or one with rechargeable or user-replaceable batteries. I don't have any particular brand in mind. Warranty, though, is a concern.

Nish Dave

 I would suggest you go for Creative's MP3 players as they offer good features, great performance and have good after-sales support in place. Creative has a long line of players to choose from; you can settle for the MuVo TX FM model. This player runs on a single AAA battery and offers decent battery life. Capacities range from 128 MB to 1 GB; prices vary according to the capacity. It also has a FM tuner. The MuVo TX FM is priced at around Rs 8K for the 256 MB model.

For printing on CDs, you need printable CDs that support this feature

Laptop With After-Sales

Q I am interested in buying a laptop in the range of Rs 35,000-40,000. On inquiring in the market I got to know about different models from various manufacturers such as Compaq's m2002, Acer's Sempron-based model and Zenith's Salespro. I need help with my purchase decision as I am confused about quality, speed and after-sales service.

Lalit Jain

 In your mentioned price range, you will get laptops based on Pentium 4, Celeron or Sempron processors, though I would still ask you to shell out a little more and opt for Centrino-based laptops. As far as raw speed is concerned, Pentium 4 and Sempron will pose no problems. I would suggest you not to look at Celeron processors as an option at all.

Digit reviewed Acer's Sempron-based laptop and found it good in terms of performance, features and price; since Acer is based out of Bangalore, service won't be a problem for you.

As far as Compaq and Zenith are concerned, Digit hasn't reviewed them so I don't have a conclusive opinion to offer. In general, though, they will be good as far as quality and service is concerned, while the performance will depend on the configuration you choose.

Video Capture Cards

Q I am interested in buying PCI-based video capture cards. Does any such card offer TV tuning capabilities? My budget is around Rs 8K, and I plan to use it to record from a VCR and handycam.

Jithin Jayaram

 There are some players in the video capture segment—Pinnacle Systems have good products, but they are priced a little higher than the others. You can look out for Pinnacle Studio 9, and external solution interfaces for your PC via the USB port, which cost around Rs 14,500.

Monarch Vision, an Indian company, also has products tailor-made for the Indian audience. The MV5 and MV20 models are priced at Rs 9K and Rs 14,800 respectively.

 Last month we gave you details on high- and low-end PCs. This month, we take a look at mid-range PCs.

Mid-Range PC		
Mid-Range	Make	Cost (Rs)
CPU	939 pin Athlon64 3000+ or 3200+	7,500
Motherboard	MSI RS480M2	6,500
RAM	512 MB DDR 400 Hynix	3,500
HDD	80 GB SATA Samsung/Seagate	2,650
Monitor	17" Acer 715 CRT	6,500
Keyboard	Logitech	300
Mouse	Logitech optical mouse	300
Cabinet	Any cabinet you like	500
Power supply	Antec / VIP 350 W power supply	2,000
Optical Drive	Lite-On / Sony combo drive	2,750
Speakers	Creative Inspire 2.1	2,400
Total		34,900



Ask Away

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